

Analysing Self-esteem in Postgraduate Physical Education Teacher Trainees

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ABSTRACT

This ex-post facto study was conducted on a non-random sample of 28 male and 45 female M.P. Ed. (I & II) students of the Department of Physical Education, Punjabi University, Patiala, during the year 2018-19, by administering to them Rosenberg Self-esteem Scale (1965) individually at one go and collecting from them their percentage academic score at the qualifying examination as documented. Comparative and correlational statistics were used to analyse the results, which conclusively showed neither any significant gender-based differences on self-esteem nor any significant relationship between self-esteem and academic score.

INTRODUCTION

Self-esteem Perspective

Often seen as a personality trait (Cherry, 2019), self-esteem is equated with self-worth or self-respect, and can be an important part of success in life - whether in studies, business, management, sport or elsewhere. Maslow (1943), in his hierarchy of needs, depicts 'self-esteem as one of the basic motivations'. In his opinion, people need esteem from other people as well as inner self-respect. Both of these shades of need must be fulfilled in order for an individual to grow as a person and achieve self-actualization – the highest goal of life. In psychology, the term self-esteem, generally, is used to describe a person's overall sense of self-worth or personal value i.e. how much you appreciate and like yourself. Rosenberg (1965) astutely described it as a “favourable or unfavourable attitude towards the self”.

Two important things about self-esteem need notice. First, being a personality trait, self-esteem intends to be stable and enduring across individuals. Second, it can involve a variety of beliefs about yourself, such as the appraisal of your own appearance, beliefs, emotions, and behaviours. Low self-esteem, which carries signs like confidence deficit, negative outlook, inability to express our needs, feeling of anxiety or shame, fear of failure, considering other better than you are, etc., may hold you back from succeeding at school work or sport because you don't believe yourself to be capable of success. Contrarily, high self-esteem signifies confidence, ability to say 'no', positive outlook, be aware of overall strengths and weakness and accept them, ability to express your needs, etc. It can help you achieve because you navigate life with a positive, assertive attitude and believe you can accomplish your goals.

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Extremely high and extremely low self-esteem levels can be harmful for these deter pursuit of your goals.

Research studies on Athletics and self-esteem are abundant. Booth (1958), Johnson (1966), Kane (1970), Merriman (1966), Tillman (1969), and Werner & Gotheil (1966) found self-esteem to be an unchallengeable personality characteristic of sportspersons. Through sport, argued Bailey et al (2010) we may enhance our self-esteem by having a positive image of our bodies and the physical skills and abilities that we develop. We feel positive self-worth through the recognition that we receive from family and friends and the social relationships that develop as a result of our involvement in sport and physical activity. Yet, we may be vulnerable to low self-esteem in sport and physical activity if we perceive our body to be inadequate, unfit or inappropriate for our selected activity. Coaches, physical education teachers and active living leaders can positively influence self-esteem and provide young people with ongoing incentive to participate and personally succeed in physical activity endeavours.

Professor Margaret Talbot, President of the International Council for Sport Sciences and Physical Education, once wrote that sports, dance and other challenging physical activities are distinctively powerful ways of helping young people learn to 'be themselves'. These activities, suggested she, can teach people how to view themselves and their potential in a new way.

Corroboration to this assertion comes from Samuels (2011) in her book *Run Like a Girls: How Strong Women Make Happy Lives*:

"Over the years that followed my 'discovery' of running, myself grew, and feeding off the accomplishments I achieved in sports - setting new personal bests, winning a little local race, surviving the setbacks of injuries and marathons gone wrong - I discovered a capacity within myself that I never knew I had. I wasn't just physically stronger than I expected, I thought of myself as a different person, as someone with more potential, broader horizons, bigger possibilities. I saw that I could push myself and take risks, not just in sports, but elsewhere, too. The competition in sports, as in life, was not with someone else, it was with myself. To "compete" was to discover my own potential to do better, to hold my own self to a higher standard, to expect more of myself-and deliver."

Using Rosenberg's Self-esteem Scale (1965), Kamlesh (1983) assessed self-esteem in 160 male and 70 female active collegiate sportspersons in 14 individual sports and team games. The study showed self-esteem to be a highly related personality trait with mixed results with regard to its overall status and differences between male and female athletes.

Objective of the Study

The objective of the study was to replicate a previous study by Kamlesh (1983) and to fish out the relationship, if any, between subjects' status in

academics and self-esteem.

Procedure

This is a post-facto (non-experimental) study, conducted on a non-random sample (intact class) of 28 male and 45 female M.P. Ed. (I & II) students of the Department of Physical Education, Punjabi University, for the session 2018-19. The mean age of the subjects was reported as 24.64 years the males and 24.16 years for the females, respectively.

The requisite data on self-esteem was collected by individually administering to the subjects the Rosenberg Self-esteem Scale (1965), which ".....is a 10-item questionnaire with fair choices for each item (on Likert Scale), ranging from strongly agree (1) to strongly disagree (4). One of the statements have reverse wording to control for response bias. A high numerical score on this scale indicates low self-esteem, while a low numerical score indicates high self-esteem. A score of 10 is the minimum and represents the high possible self-esteem, while the maximum is 40, representing the lowest possible self-esteem" (Rosenberg, 1965). The author reports the reproducibility of the scale as 92% with

a test-retest reliability value of 0.85. Not more than 10 minutes were allowed to the subjects for recording their response to the test items. Demographic data i.e. name, age, gender, academic score, etc., were entered by the subjects themselves on the response sheet.

The response sheets were scored as per procedure contained in the test description. Appropriate comparative and relationships statistics were employed to treat the data in line with the objectives of the study and conclusions drawn accordingly.

Hypotheses

On the basis of literature search, it was hypothesized that

- (i) Postgraduate physical education students wouldn't exhibit higher than average level of self-esteem.
- (ii) There would be no gender-based differences in self-esteem.
- (iii) No significant relationship between self-esteem and academic status of the subjects could be visualized.

RESULTS & DISCUSSION

Results of the study are summed up in Tables 1 and 2 and discussed as required.

Table-1 : Gender-based Comparative Statistics on Self-esteem

<i>Gender Group</i>	<i>N</i>	<i>Mean</i>	<i>t ratio</i>	<i>Significance</i>
Male	28	27.96 ± 4.14	0.4625*	NS at 0.05 level
Female	45	27.58 ± 2.98		

Statistics in Table 1 indicate that (a) the level of self-esteem both in male and female subjects is far below the norm i.e. 20, as stipulated in the self-esteem scale

description (Rosenberg, 1965), and (b) the mean difference in self-esteem among subject groups is non-significant for the required value for the mean difference to be

significant at 72df is 2.00 (Garret, 1981). While Maccoby & Jacklin (1974), Wylie (1979) does not find reliable differences in self-esteem between men and women and thus uphold this position, the studies of Belinky et al (1986), Gilligan (1982), Markus & Oyserman (1988), Miller (1986), and Stewart & Lykes (1985), in contrast, put up a strong counter argument against this finding. Kamlesh (1983) gave no decisive verdict with regard to difference in self-esteem between male and female subjects.

However, the self-esteem level both in men and women in previous and present studies is not up to the mark when juxtaposed with the norm – the lower the score on the scale, the higher the self-esteem in the subject (Rosenberg, 1965).

Hence, the results of the study straight away uphold the null hypotheses (i) and (ii). Interestingly, greater response variability is visible in the male sample, which could be due to an unknown extraneous factor.

Table-2 : Relationship between self-esteem and academic scores

<i>Combined Sample</i>	<i>N</i>	<i>Combined Mean Self-esteem</i>	<i>Combined Mean Academic Score (%age)</i>	<i>Coefficient of Correlation</i>
Male & Female	73	27.79± 4.15	72.34 ±7.47	0.0116*

*non-significant

Statistics in Table 2, reveal (a) the mean academic score of the combined sample to be pretty high but mean score on self-esteem far below the expectation, and (b) the relationship between the two variables i.e. subjects' academic score and self-esteem virtually non-existent, which shows acceptance of the null (no difference) hypothesis (iii).

CONCLUSIONS

Within the limits and limitations of the study, it is concluded that (a) male and female postgraduate physical education teacher-trainee students don't differ on the level of self-esteem, and (b) their academic score and self-esteem status are unrelated.

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